

[Return to Search](#)

Religion, morality, and the person

Author(S): Fortes, Meyer, Goody, Jack

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 308

Culture (OWC): [Tallensi \(FE11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1934-1937; 1971

Coverage Date: 1930-1971

Place Coverage: Tongo Village, Ghana

Section Title(S): 5 Ritual And Office • 6 Totem And Taboo

32 Recent references are given in Richards (1960).

[View in context](#)

121
Theoretical
Orientation

33 Details are given in Fortes (1949).

[View in context](#)

121
Theoretical
Orientation

34 Richards (1960).

[View in context](#)

121
Theoretical
Orientation

35 See references in Fortes (1945). Similar annual public ceremonies are widespread in West Africa and play the same part in politico-ritual relations. Cf. the Ashanti *Adae* and *Odwira* ceremonies described by Rattray (1927), Ch. XII, and the first-fruit rites of the Yakö (Forde, (1949)).

[View in context](#)

121
Theoretical
Orientation

36 See Fortes (1949) for further details of such transactions.

[View in context](#)

121

Theoretical
Orientation

37 The sanctity of this rite is enhanced by the belief that an oath which is peculiarly binding is one that is sworn by the Earth. This oath is sworn by touching the Earth with a wet finger and licking the finger.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

38 See Forde (1957), p. 11, for an illuminating comment on similar ideas among the Yakö.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

39 I here summarize data given the more fully in Fortes (1949), but I failed, there, to appreciate the significance I now see in these facts.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

40 See Rattray (1927), Ch. VI. It is worth noting that both Fustel de Coulanges (1864), Ch. VIII, and Van Gennep (*op. cit.*, p. 101) perceived what I am here restating.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

41 See Fortes (1959).

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

42 See Fortes in Goody (ed.), 1958, *No. 1, loc. cit.*

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

1 Or, in the more disingenuous jargon of today, 'developing' and 'developed' societies.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

2 I use the term 'totemic' in the inclusive sense given to it by Evans-Pritchard (1956).

121
Theoretical
Orientation

[View in context](#)

3 Cf. Rattray, R. S., 1932. 'Totemic' observances are discussed and listed for the 'Nankanse' in Vol. I, Ch. XVIII, p. 232 sqq. and for the other 'tribes' of the area in the relevant chapters in Vol II. Rattray was apparently not acquainted

121
Theoretical
Orientation

with the earlier French literature on peoples of the same linguistic and cultural family (the Voltaic peoples) as those he investigated in the then Northern Territories of the Gold Coast.

[View in context](#)

4 Delafosse's conclusions on the subject of totemism in this area are trenchantly summarized in his paper of 1920. Other French contributions to Voltaic ethnology at this period are referred to in Fortes, 1945.

121
[Theoretical
Orientation](#)

[View in context](#)

5 In his 1935 paper 'On the concept of function in social science' there is a revealing footnote which reads (1952: 181) 'Opposition, i.e. organised and regulated antagonism is, of course, an essential feature of every social system.' His theory of the joking relationship presents it as an institutionalized device for resolving a structural opposition, and his whole approach to ritual and to kinship theory was influenced by the same idea. His pupils used it to good effect — e.g. in the brilliant analysis of 'good sacred' and 'bad sacred' by M. N. Srinivas, 1952. As for Malinowski, his classical presentation of the opposition between Trobriand  309 father and mother's brother is evidence enough of his implicit recognition of the same principle.

121
[Theoretical
Orientation](#)

[View in context](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)